



Information Security Policy

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Contents

1.0	Purpose.....	2
2.0	Scope.....	2
3.0	Policy Statements: Information Security Framework.....	3
3.1	Know what you have.....	3
3.2	Assess the risks.....	5
3.3	Protect.....	6
3.4	Govern and review.....	10
3.0	Policy Compliance.....	11
4.0	Related Documentation.....	11
5.0	Policy Document Control.....	13

1.0 Purpose

As a university we share, collaborate on and manage information. Information that is essential for the day-to-day operations of a university, including: research; teaching; knowledge exchange; administration; partnership; and community work.

Information security is the framework of controls around policy, physical security, technical security, training, and organisational culture that help to protect the information that is valuable to the University.

This Policy is based on the following standards, regulations, and legislation:

- UK General Data Protection Regulation (UK GDPR) and ICO Guidance
- Data Protection Act 2018
- Investigatory Powers (Interception by Businesses etc, for Monitoring & Record Keeping Purposes) Regulations 2018
- ISO/IEC 27001/ 27002
- NCSC Cyber Essentials Scheme and NCSC Cyber Security Toolkit for Boards
- UK AI Playbook

2.0 Scope

Any individual who handles information on behalf of the university as part of their work or role (students, staff, researchers, honorary staff, and third parties carrying out a university function) must adhere to this Policy.

This policy relates to securing university information and working to ensure an appropriate balance of the confidentiality, integrity, availability and safety of the information and systems. Information that is valuable to the university (whether owned, generated by, or entrusted to the University) should be protected from theft, misuse, or compromise that could impact:

- an individual's reasonable expectations of privacy, security, and safety.
- the university's ability to carry out its work.
- the university's reputation and ability to meet legal, ethical, and regulatory requirements.

Information can be written, electronic, or verbal and can include (but is not limited to): email correspondence; published documents; teaching material; plans and strategy documents; exam papers and assessments; data, analysis, and findings (both research and institutional data); information held on student and staff systems; disciplinary or grievance proceedings. Whatever the form, valuable and sensitive information must be appropriately protected throughout its lifecycle (collecting, storing, using, sharing, transferring, retaining and disposal).

This policy supports and should be read in conjunction with (sits alongside) the Data Protection Policy, Records Retention Schedule, IT Acceptable Use Policy, Information Management Policy and the Information Protection Guide (see Related Documentation Section for links).

3.0 Policy Statements: Information Security Framework

An information security framework is effective when using layers of security controls: physical; policy; personnel; technical; and incident management. It is not sufficient to solely rely on IT Services or a previous legacy set up. All users of university information must apply a combination of controls and safeguards, to maintain and protect the confidentiality, integrity, availability, and safety of university information.

Four simple principles apply:

1. Know what you have
2. Assess the risks
3. Protect
4. Govern and Review

3.1 Know what you have

Requires clear ownership of and responsibility for assets. Every piece of University information — digital or paper — should have a clear owner/ custodian.

A. Accountable Owners: Business or Data Owners/ Custodians

All information must have a clearly defined owner or custodian – called a Business or Data Owner/ Custodian. This is usually the senior person responsible and accountable for the function that creates and uses that information from creation to consumption and end of use (e.g., Dean, Head of Department, Principal Investigator, Research / Academic Supervisor, Manager, etc.). The Business or Data Owner/ Custodian may be at any level in the organisation – a small team or even a sole researcher, with responsibility for protecting the information they have been entrusted with.

For consistency of scope, the term 'Data Owner' will be used in this policy.

The Data Owner is responsible for putting rules and processes in place around access, use, quality and accuracy, storage and security, and ensuring compliance with those documented rules. Data ownership also applies to each individual user who stores and processes university information and is responsible for protecting it.

B. Asset Registers

Data Owners must know what data, infrastructure, IT equipment, information and IT systems, software, cloud services, and storage they use. This is key to informing and maintaining Departmental Business Continuity Plans.

Data Owners are responsible for ensuring their data is securely managed regardless of location i.e., whether in local departmental systems, in IT Services centrally managed facilities and services or in third party hosted solutions. The Infrastructure Management Code of Practice provides clear standards on secure management of assets (see the Related Documentation section).

Data Owners (or their delegates), whether at a business area, school, department, or faculty level must maintain and update an Asset Register ([See Knowledge Article Information Security: Asset Registers](#)). Data Owners should notify IT Services, of new devices or

systems before they are procured and connected. This is to ensure end user devices are appropriately protected and managed ([See IT Services> Computer Security](#)), and to ensure the Data/ System Owner carries out appropriate assessment and security checks. See Section 3.2 Assess the risks.

IT Services maintain an asset register of centrally managed applications, systems and services as recorded in the IT Service catalogue.

C. System Owner/ Administrator

System Owners/ Administrators are nominated roles: in charge of and responsible for managing the systems which provide the service. This role is sometimes also referred to as Data Steward.

i. Centrally managed IT facilities

The IT Services Department (IT Services) is the System Owner/ Administrator for the university's centrally managed IT facilities, storage, systems, services, and infrastructure ("IT facilities and services") that underpin university information assets. IT Services staff, as system owners/ administrators for named systems, will work in collaboration with the Data Owner to manage and protect the information. See Section 3.3 Protect and Section 3.4 Govern & Review

ii. System owner/ administrator for non-centrally managed IT facilities

If university departments have established local information systems which are not centrally managed or supported by IT Services, the Data Owner, and their nominated system owners/ administrators must manage and protect these facilities to the same minimum-security baseline standards as IT Services. See the Infrastructure Management Code of Practice (Related Documentation section) and Section 3.3 Protect.

D. Users and Acceptable Use

The university IT Acceptable Use Policy (AUP) (See Related Documentation) outlines expected behaviours that all Users of IT facilities and services (students, staff, researchers, honorary members, and third parties carrying out a university function) must comply with. The AUP includes rules for the acceptable and prohibited use of university IT facilities and services, including responsibility for protecting University information. It links to relevant misconduct and/or disciplinary policies in the event of misuse.

E. Training and Awareness

The university is committed to supporting and promoting staff awareness of their information security responsibilities through a framework of policies, guidance, webpages, team briefings, staff obligatory e-learning and cyber security awareness training (See Related Documentation section).

Training should be appropriate to role. For example, system owners/ administrators with privileged access, or business areas who regularly handle high risk information, should undertake appropriate training, and adhere to documented operating procedures. Data owners, as part of their Faculty and Department structure and responsibilities for protecting

university information, are responsible for organising relevant training within their business area to enable staff to protect university information and infrastructure.

3.2 Assess the risks

When planning to procure or develop new information systems, IT facilities and services, the data and system owners should give as much advance notice as possible to relevant central professional services departments (including, but not limited to: IT Services, Legal, Finance and Procurement). This is to:

- ensure effective use of university resources (financial, infrastructure and workforce).
- prioritise workload against existing demands.
- ensure the system meets the minimum-security baseline (see section 3.3 Protect) and [enterprise architecture principles](#)
- assess the impact, and potential integration with current university systems.
- assess and build in data protection privacy and transparency requirements.

This Information Security Policy supports Data Owners and System Owners to carry out an appropriate assessment by signposting relevant processes and templates. See [Knowledge Article Information Security: Risk assessment](#) for an overview of key information risk assessment processes.

Emerging Technologies: It is important to build in risk assessment, planning and security assessment before obtaining or using new technologies, such as Artificial Intelligence (AI), Cloud or Internet of Things (IoT) devices. This is to identify and weigh both the potential positive impacts of new technologies as well as any negative impacts, lack of security controls or other unintended consequences.

Where, following risk assessment, baseline requirements cannot be met, an exception to the minimum-security baseline should be raised. Although exceptions will be assessed and recorded by IT Services, it is the data owner/ system owner responsibility to document, own and mitigate the risks.

Data Classification: Assessing and classifying information using the Data classification scheme (Figure 1 below) focuses effort and resources into identifying and protecting the most sensitive and valuable information. Figure 1 below summarises the three data classifications which underpin this Information Security Policy.

Public	Internal	Confidential
Information intended for sharing in the public domain	Information used for day-to-day University functions not for general public Default classification	Any quantity of <u>Personal data</u> (about living people) or information with contractual, business or research value
Impact if breached: No adverse impact	Impact if breached: Some adverse impact and disruption to services. Possible breach of	Impact if breached: Serious privacy or reputational risk, financial impact, commercial disadvantage or disruption to services

Public	Internal	Confidential
	confidence or statutory duty	Breach of statutory / regulatory duty / risk of fine
Information categorised as PUBLIC does not need any special handling requirements.	Access should be appropriate to role and is protected by min. one barrier e.g., username and password for technical security. ID access control or locked office / cupboard for physical security. Use centrally managed IT facilities (approved cloud and University premises)	Access should be: appropriate to role and authorised by the Data/ Business Owner; protected with more than one barrier; encrypted when in transit; shared only with appropriate personnel; securely destroyed at end of use. Use centrally managed IT facilities and services (on university premises and approved Cloud) incl. full disk encryption on all mobile storage devices

The Three-Step Protection Process

Step 1: Classify your information

Use the definitions and examples in the [Information Protection Guide](#) to decide whether your data is *Public*, *Internal*, or *Confidential*. When in doubt, treat it as Internal by default.

Step 2: Handle it appropriately

Store, share, and use data in line with its classification. The [Information Protection Guide](#) outlines the right tools and practices — from secure devices and approved storage options to sharing protocols and standards.

Step 3: Protect it throughout its lifecycle

Security doesn't stop once data is created or shared. Follow guidance on secure storage, considerations for responsible AI use, sharing sensitivity labels, and safe disposal. Each level builds on the one before it — Confidential data needs all Internal protections, plus extra safeguards.

Accountability and exceptions: There may be limited circumstances where the Data Owner (Principal Investigator, Supervisor or Head of Department/ Institute) has a requirement to store classified information differently, or with increased safeguards, to the protection measures in this Guide. The Data Owner is responsible for implementing and documenting the appropriate protection to comply with relevant standards e.g. Government (HMG) Policy.

3.3 Protect

IT Services provide and are responsible for ensuring centrally managed IT facilities and services meet external security standards, self-assessments, audits, and other regulatory frameworks. Data/ system owners are responsible for adhering to the same standards for

any locally procured or legacy systems. Systems should be designed to be secure and for security not to be considered as an afterthought.

Property & Campus Services Campus Support service helps to ensure a safe and secure environment. Campus Support team provide 24/7 support over 365 days per year and also provide advice on physical security measures.

Security standards are a pre-requisite for organisations to collaborate on research, obtain funding or to obtain and use partner organisation's data. Relevant standards and certifications include (but are not limited to):

- NCSC Cyber Essentials
- NHS Data Security & Protection Toolkit (DSPT),
- Office for National Statistics (ONS),
- Payment Card Industry Data Security Standard (PCI DSS),
- Web Accessibility Standard WCAG2.2 AA/ EN 301 549
- Cyber Assurance and Security audit.

Failure to meet required security standards may invalidate or breach Data Sharing Contracts or agreements with partners, leading to withdrawal or termination.

Protection measures and standards are reflected within the University across 4 main aspects:

A. Minimum-security baseline

The minimum-security baseline is a requirement across all university IT facilities and services, to comply with information and cyber security requirements as well as external security certifications. A programme of work is underway within IT Services to mitigate risks within centrally managed legacy systems to meet the minimum-security baseline (listed below) or update to compliant solutions.

Proposals to buy new or to upgrade existing IT facilities and services must be submitted to IT services for assessment and approval. The Supplier Security Questionnaire (SSQ) provides security due diligence on a supplier and their solution/ service to operate in a secure manner **before** entrusting the supplier with university data. This SSQ process and the [Supplier Security Management SOP](#) helps departments to minimise and manage risk to their data and to the university infrastructure and reputation.

See [Knowledge Article Information Security: risk assessment](#) for steps to initiate a Supplier Security Questionnaire (items 1-3). The table below lists the minimum-security baseline and secure design requirements.

Minimum-security baseline	
Authentication and account management	All systems must be protected with Multi-Factor Authentication (MFA) All systems must be protected with the university central IT authentication (IT Services Single Sign On (SSO)) Supplier should have: clearly defined account management procedures for own staff and their third parties: authentication and authorisation; and technical security measures to prevent a malicious

	or compromised user in the Supplier environment from affecting the data or service.
Activity logging	Audit trail of user and system actions and events to provide traceability of the use of a service.
Vulnerability management	Systems and infrastructure are underpinned by operating system and software applications which need to be checked (scanned) and fixed (patched) to reduce vulnerability to cyber-attack. Supplier should have an active vulnerability and patch management procedure and be able to apply patches for critical and high severity vulnerabilities in line with Cyber Essentials requirements.
Antimalware protection	All IT systems, cloud services, and computing devices (infrastructure and endpoint) must have antimalware protection.
Encryption	University data should be protected in transit (transmitted across the internet - at least TLS1.2) and at rest (AES256).
Design	
Hosting	Hosting arrangements must be clearly defined. Only necessary network services to be accessed from the internet to reduce exposure to attack. IT Services to assess and approve in line with Remote Access Policy (see Related Documentation).
Integrations & Design	Technologies, protocols and web browsers etc should be actively maintained and be supported (i.e. receiving updates and patches). Role based access control and separation of environments is recommended. Data flow and integrations with existing systems should be clearly defined and secured. Will be subject to assessment by IT Services using Enterprise Architecture Principles.
Back Up, Resilience and Availability	Regularly taking backups of data, testing restores and having detailed assurances about the resilience and availability of a system is essential. Supplier to provide information about their back-up solution, disaster recovery process and service & support package. Department Business Continuity Plans should incorporate back up resilience and availability of locally managed systems.
Artificial Intelligence (AI)	Use of AI must be identified and privacy settings enabled to ensure Internal and Confidential data is not used to train public Large Language Models (LLM's) or used for any other purpose not explicitly agreed to.
Configuration of equipment	Computers and network devices should be configured to reduce vulnerabilities and provide only the services required to fulfil their role.

	See also Infrastructure Management Code of Practice and Shared Responsibility Matrix
Compliance	Systems must comply with relevant external security standards and University Policy (see Related Documentation section)

B. Information Handover and End of Use

All university information should be returned to the university when users leave or move to another role (i.e., staff, researchers, students, honorary members, and third parties carrying out a university function). This includes informing appropriate staff of [information handover arrangements](#) to ensure the university retains ownership and custody of the information.

All members of the university should comply with the [University Retention Schedule](#) for end of use secure disposal or preservation of information. Internal and Confidential information should be 'destroyed beyond the ability to recover it' (paying due regard to environmental and legislative requirements around waste and hazardous waste processing). Secure disposal arrangements for data bearing IT equipment and sensitive/ confidential paper waste are subject to contracts and documented procedures. This is to manage the chain of custody; securely erase or destroy the data; and provide destruction certification from the third-party services.

- **IT Services** has a contract with a third-party IT Asset Disposal Partner for secure disposal of all **data bearing IT equipment**. Information remains on IT equipment even when a user has deleted the file, therefore secure erasure, and disposal of IT equipment via the IT Services contracted service is mandatory. Donating university computing equipment or removing data storage from computing devices are not secure destruction methods and constitute a breach of University Policy. It is each Department's and School's responsibility to ensure all data bearing IT equipment including end user devices are collected and securely erased by the contracted IT Asset Disposal Partner. <https://www.liverpool.ac.uk/it/my-computer/disposal/>
- **IT Services (Information & Records Management team)** provide appropriate facilities enabling staff to carry out secure disposal of **sensitive paper waste** via secure locked consoles or confidential waste bags (which are collected and shredded by a third-party contractor). Contact the Information & Records Management team for advice on disposal of non-paper confidential waste e.g., USBs and CDs. <https://www.liverpool.ac.uk/it/records-management/storage-and-disposal/confidential-waste/>

C. Incident Reporting:

All Users of university information, IT facilities and services are responsible for reporting data loss and security incidents.

- Report a loss or compromise of personal data **immediately** to the university Data Protection Officer. See <https://www.liverpool.ac.uk/intranet/legal/data-protection-foi-staff/data-breach/> Ensure your Line Manager is also aware.

- Contact IT Services Service Desk immediately <https://www.liverpool.ac.uk/it/getting-help/>. via Phone: +44 (0)151 794 4567.

D. Cyber Security Incident Response Team (CSIRT):

The CSIRT is a cross functional team of IT Services staff, with support from Legal & Governance staff, who respond to IT security incidents and policy breaches, associated IT Investigation requests, activity, and vulnerability reporting.

A core function of the CSIRT is to effectively investigate the cause(s) of an IT security incident and implement measures to recover and to mitigate risk to the university.

The CSIRT may pass information relating to an IT security incident or breach to external organisations for information or further action. These may include (but are not limited to) the Information Commissioner's Office (ICO), the Police or other Statutory bodies.

3.4 Govern and review

A security governance framework is not just policy compliance. It is about embedding responsibility for information across all aspects of university work. Enabling the culture that recognises the value and importance of data, how it underpins our business goals, and how it supports all aspects of university research, teaching and learning, professional services, and wider collaboration.

This policy is part of the foundations supporting the university to control, direct and communicate cyber security risk management activities, through a Cyber Security Awareness programme.

Information Governance Committee

The remit of the [Information Governance Committee](#) (which reports to the Senior Leadership Team and risk oversight to Audit Committee) helps to set direction and be accountable for information governance related policies and management arrangements to ensure they are compatible with the strategic direction of the organisation: handling and protecting information throughout its lifecycle. This includes monitoring compliance with Information Governance related policies and oversight of information risk management.

Business Continuity

As part of our commitment of continuous improvement, the University has developed a Business Resilience Policy which replaces the previous Business Continuity Policy.

Council oversees the University Business Continuity capabilities through the Health and Safety Committee and the Business Resilience Steering Group, enabling an integrated and collaborative resilience approach.

All schools and departments are responsible for developing, training and testing their respective local Business Continuity Plans (BCP's). Risk based scenarios including the loss of IT Services and the impacts should be included in their planning assumptions and consequence management arrangements.

IT Services supports all stakeholders across the university in helping to mitigate the risks associated to cyber security and infrastructure related incidents through the Business Continuity and Disaster Recovery planning processes.

Payment Card Data Security

The university has an established PCI steering group which oversees the teams managing all payment card processing (and cardholder information) across the university. The Payment Card Industry Data Security Standard (PCI DSS) Finance Policy specifies the rules for protecting the security of all card payments received and processed by the University (see related Documentation section below).

Operating Procedures and documentation

Senior Management Teams should oversee and validate that documented procedures are in place for system/ information use e.g. Standard Operating Procedures (SOPs). Data and System Owners should ensure they have implemented relevant controls: responsibilities, risk assessment, protection, and governance measures as outlined in this Information Security Policy. Examples of required SOPs include: system administrators with privileged access; researchers receiving NHS health and care data for research purposes; and PCI DSS users.

4.0 Policy Compliance

Failure to comply with this Policy and the supporting Information Protection Guide in protecting university information (or that entrusted to us by a third party) puts the university at risk of reputational damage, financial penalty, breach of legal, contractual or regulatory requirement. It may also lead to disciplinary action in accordance with the relevant Disciplinary Policy (staff or student) or misconduct investigation in accordance with relevant Misconduct Policy.

5.0 Related Documentation

This section lists directly relevant guidance and policies that have been referenced within this Information Security Policy. This policy is subject to annual review which includes a check that hyperlinks within the document are active and up to date. Please contact the IT Services Service Desk to report any broken links, or to raise specific queries.

Public Policies

- [JANET \(UK\) Connection, Security & Acceptable Use Policies](#)
- [IT Acceptable Use Policy](#) (AUP)-Acceptable and prohibited use of university IT facilities & services
- [Data Protection Policy](#) – Data Protection controls
- [Bring Your Own Device \(BYOD\) Policy](#) – requirements that personally owned devices must meet
- [Information Protection Guide](#) – signposts practical guidance to protect data through lifecycle
- [Information Management Policy](#) – responsibilities when managing information
- [Business Resilience Policy](#)
- [Finance Payment Card Industry Data Security Standard \(PCI DSS\) Policy](#)
- [Research Data Management Policy](#)
- [Export Controls](#)

- [Staff-related Policies](#) including Staff Disciplinary
- [Research-related Policies](#) including Research Misconduct
- [Student-related Policies](#) including Student Conduct & Discipline and Academic Integrity

Internal university policy and procedure (for registered users)

- [Network Access Policy](#) – rules for connecting a device to the University network (wired or wireless)
- [Remote Access Policy](#) – lists authorised tools to remotely access University IT resources or for 3rd parties to provide remote support. It includes University approach to use of remote access tools that are not authorised
- [Infrastructure Management Code of Practice](#) – technical security requirements that owners should have in place for infrastructure that they manage
- [Identity & Access Management \(IdAM\) Standard](#)
- [NHS DSPT SOP035](#) – part of permission to proceed requirements for Researchers undergoing Sponsorship Office approval
- PCI DSS SOP
- [Supplier Security Management SOP](#)
- System Administrator Charter – available on request from IT Security team leader
- [Central IT Services Authentication](#)
- [Data Protection Impact Assessment](#)
- [Retention Schedule](#)
- [IT Services webpages](#)
- [IT Services Intranet site](#)
- [IT Services self-service portal](#)
- [Obligatory Training](#): GDPR & Information Security E-learning (Learn Well)
- [Behind the Hack](#): Cyber security Training

6.0 Policy Document Control

Policy Version Control			
Author	Summary of changes	Version	Authorised & Date
ISO (Christa Price)	Annual revisions to existing policy to align with IT governance and organisational change. Linked documents are listed in Section 5.0 Relation Documentation of the Policy	V5.3	Council: 26/02/2026 Audit Committee: 12/02/2026 via Email Votes SLT: 26/01/2026 IGC: 14/01/2026 IT Architecture:17/12/25 IT SMT: 05/12/2025
ISO (C. Price)	Revisions to align with IT strategy and minimum-security baseline	V5.2	IGC: 22/01/25 IT SMT: Jan 2025 ITS Architecture:05/02/25
ISO (C. Price)	Minor revision and annual review	V5.1	IGC: Email: 24/10/2024
Information Security Officer (C. Price)	Major revision to reflect IT Services digital strategy and priorities to meet assurance requirements	V5.0	IGC: Chairs Approval (KR): 09/05/2023 ITS SMT: 05/05/2023 ITS Architecture:03/05/23
Information Security Officer (C. Price)	Minor revisions to reflect dept name changes and related documentation	V4.1	IGC: 15/10/2021
Information Security Officer (Christa Price)	Major revision of policy including revised data classification. Policy replaces: Information Security Policy V3.0, Information Asset Classification Policy V1.2, Workspace & IT Equipment Policy V1.0, InfoSecurity Review Policy V1.2	V4.0	IGC: 14/10/2019 Formal Senior Leadership Team: 04/11/2019 Council: 20/11/2019
J.Cartwright,S.Byrne, C.Woof, S.Aldridge,	Subject to reviews Sep 2015, 2016 and 2017. No major changes	V3.0	Council: 28/11/2011
Policy Management & Responsibilities			
Owner	This policy is owned by the Group Director IT & Digital on behalf of the Information Governance Committee. The Group Director IT & Digital has the authority to issue and communicate university-wide policy on IT facilities and services, including information security priorities and has delegated responsibility for the day-to-day development, implementation, and		

	communication of the policy to the Information Security Officer (Author, listed above).
Consultation	The policy contents and approach are tested and subject to discussion and feedback through day to day interaction between university departments and IT services, particularly initiation of new projects, renewal of systems and services, as well as communication via Cyber Champions network (quarterly discussion forum for IT services security teams with technical and security representatives from University Faculty, Schools and Departments. Policy is also subject to annual review and endorsement via the Information Governance Committee.
Equality Impact Assessment	There is no positive or negative impact of this Policy on equality groups and there are no implications for the University's compliance with the Equality Act.
Data Protection	This Policy outlines the security requirements the university should implement to support and evidence compliance with the sixth data protection principle: processed securely / integrity and confidentiality.
Regulatory Compliance	This annual review of the Information Security Policy incorporates changes from external security standards including PCI DSS, NCSC Cyber Essentials, NHS Data Security & Protection Toolkit (DSPT). Failure to meet these external standards may invalidate data sharing agreements and partnership collaboration terms. 1. Does this Policy continue to uphold the OfS Public Interest Governance Principles? Yes. It is a high-level principles document that outlines how all members of the University should protect University information and infrastructure, as well as partner data entrusted to us. In particular, the Policy underpins principles of governance, accountability and risk management and outlines standards for integrity – both the integrity and accuracy of data and expected behaviours of university members. 2. How does this Policy relate to freedom of speech and academic freedom? This Policy outlines the standards and principles to protect the confidentiality, integrity and availability of university information and infrastructure. It is closely aligned to the IT Acceptable Use Policy (AUP) which lists expected and prohibited behaviours when using IT facilities and services. The AUP was revised in September 2025 to incorporate and to uphold freedom of speech and academic freedom.
Policy Review	
Review due:	Annually by March 2027
Document Location:	ITS webpages https://www.liverpool.ac.uk/it/regulations/ University Policy Repository https://www.liverpool.ac.uk/policy-centre/
** The Owner & Author are responsible for publicising this policy document.**	